versies around halal-certified products or Muslim-owned eateries near Kanwar Yatra routes, a pattern has emerged where Hindu victimhood is framed against a vague but menacing 'Islamic threat'. The anti-conversion law in UP has been criticised by rights groups for being used exclusively against Muslims, even where conversions are voluntary. The state has defended such campaigns as necessary for protecting vulnerable citizens, especially women, from coercion or deceit.

THE MONEY TRAIL

Chhangur has been in the sights of the police for long. In November 2024, the UP ATS filed an FIR against him after a preliminary probe into allegations of mass conversions, foreign funding and even national security threats in the form of using a large building as a "terror training camp" as well as suspected links with Pakistan's Inter Services Intelligence (ISI). The FIR also alleges collusion with local police and intelligence units.

Chhangur and his gang, the police and ATS allege, targeted poor and vulnerable non-Muslim individuals for conversion to Islam through inducements of money, coercion, emotional pressure and, in some cases, false promises of marriage. They say the group laundered crores of rupees, bought benami properties, expanded such operations to Maharashtra and Nepal, travelled frequently to Gulf countries and maintained over 40 Indian bank accounts. Foreign currency inflows from West Asia—apparently used for conversion purposes, money-laundering and buying property—are now under Enforcement Directorate scrutiny, with suspicious transactions pegged at around Rs 100 crore. Several Vostro accounts—a bank account held for transactions with a foreign bank—connected to co-accused Naveen Rohra and held in UAE-linked banks, are also being inspected by the ED. At least two bank accounts in Neetu's name received suspected foreign remittances. In Naveen's accounts, investigators flagged two large inward transfers of Rs 16.22 crore and Rs 18.66 crore via NEFT, along with additional foreign remittances routed through UAE-based exchange services.

Investigators claim Chhangur's group followed a caste-based cash reward rate, payable to persons actually bringing about successful conversions: Rs 15-16 lakh for converting an upper-caste woman, Rs 10-12 lakh for women from Other Backward Classes (OBC) and Rs 8-10 lakh for converting persons from Scheduled Castes and other communities. The ultimate objective, allege ATS sources, was to undermine the social fabric of Hindu society through specifically targeting vulnerable and poor Hindu women;



SUMIT KUMAR


ANI

CASE FILE CHHANGUR BABA

- Seven people arrested so far, including Chhangur Baba, his son Mehboob and close associates Naveen and Neetu Rohra
- Gang members are said to have made some 40 trips to Middle East countries
- The group allegedly acquired property worth over Rs 100 crore in a few years, with structures often built without required land-use approvals
- ED also inspecting vostro accounts with large inward transfers operated by co-accused Naveen held in UAE-linked banks
- Two accounts in Neetu's name allegedly received foreign remittances too